Vitthala Temple, Krishna Temple, Achyutaraya Temple and more. The ‘urban core’ has palaces, audience halls and homes of people who lived in stone dwellings (the rest lived elsewhere in homes made of perishable materials). It has the baths of elite residents as well as tanks and aqueducts. Prominent sites are the Queen’s Bath and the Mahanavami Platform. Smaller religious sites exist too, including the Hazara Rama Temple and a couple of mosques. Military barracks and stables also appear in the ‘urban core’.

I soon realize that the best way to experience Vijayanagar is to wander its sprawling ruins all day, beyond the tourist hotspots, armed with a water bottle, a map and guidebooks (avoiding those ‘heritage pride’ books that uncritically glorify its past while hiding unsavoury details[2]). The site requires much patience and study. One must linger there for days and get lost a few times before it yields itself more fully to the visitor. It then reveals new meanings and stories in its sculptures and layout, illuminating in the mind’s eye the city in its heyday: its public spaces, social lives, ideas of order and beauty.

As I explore Vijayanagar’s fortifications—and the concentric stone walls around its royal centre—I begin to imagine the threat of war its residents must have felt. Seeing its network of canals and tanks, I begin to see how it became a city of gardens and orchards. It is one thing to read that Vijayanagar was the sacred and commercial hub of the empire, quite another to absorb the sheer number and scale of its temples and the bazaars around them, lining long streets with single and double-storeyed stone pavilions, often with beautifully carved columns.